

IN CONTEXT

Funen

Funen (known as Fyn in Danish), where Nielsen was born and grew up, is the third largest of Denmark's many islands. It is renowned for its fertile farmland and natural beauty, which has given rise to its nomination as "the garden of Denmark." Nielsen's autobiography, *My Childhood on Funen* (1927), has an honored place in Danish literature. The capital of the island is Odense, where there is a museum devoted to Nielsen and his sculptor wife.



WINDMILL IN EGESKOV, FUNEN, DENMARK

Carl Nielsen was born in Sortelung on the isle of Funen (see [box](#)), the seventh of 12 children in a poor family. His father was a house painter who supplemented his income by playing the violin and cornet at weddings and other events. By the age of six, Carl was learning to play his father's instruments and he wrote his earliest compositions two or three years later. He joined a